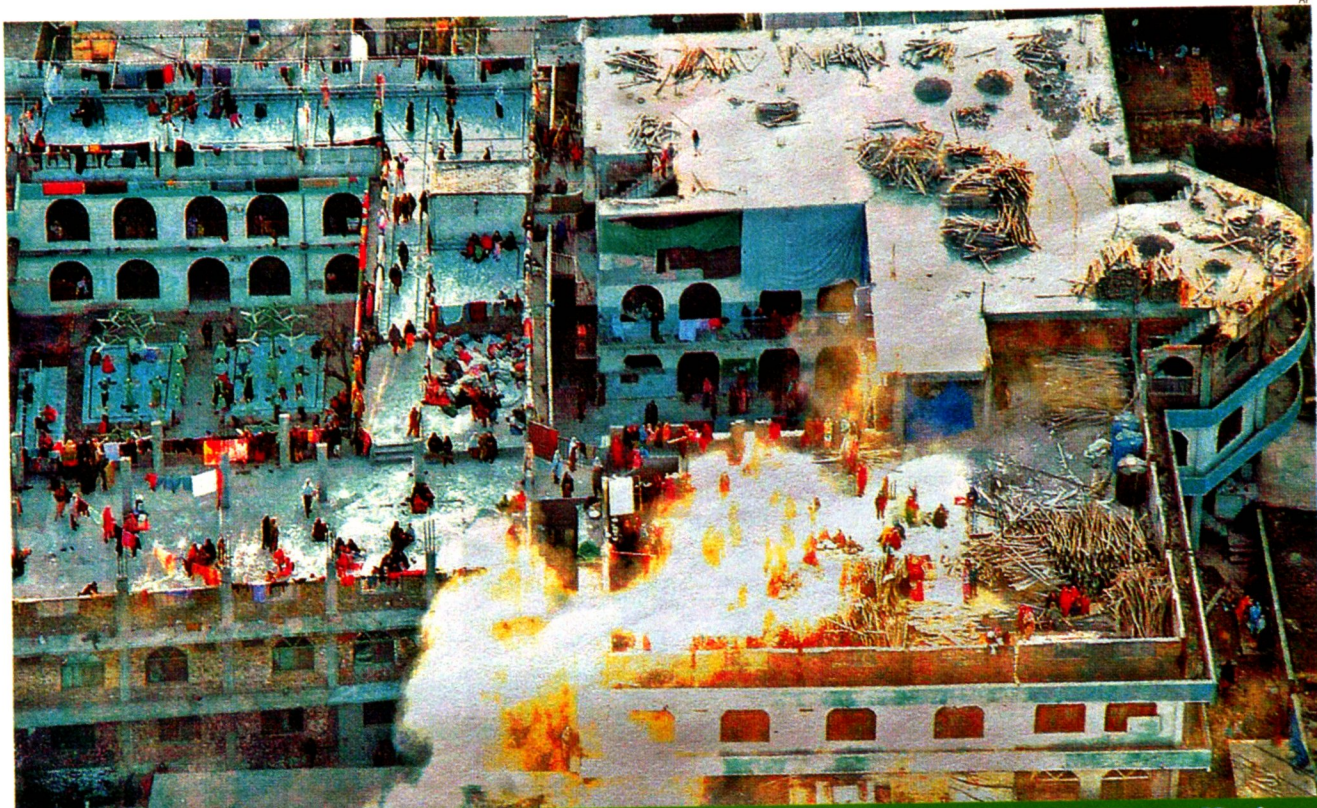




★ After the Lal Masjid showdown, fundamentalists have been strident in their opposition to Musharraf. ★

is stipulated in the Constitution, through a weighted electoral college of the federal and provincial parliaments. While he has the strength to carry through his election in the current assemblies, there is a serious risk attached to entrusting the presidential polls to a fresh parliament after general elections, since he may not have the numbers in it for a smooth sail.

On the other hand, his political adversaries, such as MMA, have threatened to resign from the assemblies should he attempt to get elected from the present parliament. Since the MMA also runs the government in the frontier province (NWFP) and is part of the coalition in Balochistan, this threat could also mean the dissolution of those assemblies, destroying the electoral college. The danger of agitation from Sharif's PML(N), which may not have the numbers in parliament but could prove a formidable foe on the

WAR ON TERROR: Religious extremists being flushed out of Lal Masjid streets, must also be considered.

In this context, the favoured option at the moment is the deal with Bhutto's Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP). Under such a deal, the PPP's support—or at least lack of opposition—would help blunt the Opposition's movement against Musharraf since it remains the largest opposition party. In the words of a government insider, "Nawaz Sharif would then become Bhutto's problem more than Musharraf's". The PPP's support in a constitutional amendment could also help overcome a possible Supreme Court challenge to Musharraf's candidacy. With PPP's support and its 81 seats in the National Assembly, the ruling coalition—which commands just over 170 seats in a 342-member National Assembly—could attain the two-thirds majority required for such an amendment.

In return, Bhutto would have the corruption cases against her quashed and a free hand to run her party's electoral campaign during the general elections. She is desperate to see an end to the corruption cases—most of which were initiated during Sharif's last tenure—and which continue to hang like the sword of Damocles over her head and tarnish her international image, especially with proceedings in international courts in Switzerland and Spain. A substantial amount of money allegedly siphoned abroad is also at stake. The cases are the prime reason she went in self-imposed exile even before Musharraf came to power.

Despite losing some ground because of the public perception of compromising with an unpopular military ruler, Bhutto's party is expected to do well in the upcoming polls, especially with good prospects of being able to form the next government. From all in-



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